

1951

The Coming Of Interactivity

March: UNIVAC I

The UNIVAC I (U N I V e r s a l A u t o m a t i c Computer), the first commercial multi-purpose computer, was delivered by Remington Rand to the US Census Bureau. Eckert and Mauchly, who we've mentioned in chapter 1, were the moving force behind it. The machine cost about \$1 million (Rs 3.6 crore now) to build, weighed 13 tons, and was as big as an one-car garage. The clock speed was 2.25 MHz, and the main I/O devices were magnetic tape and punch-cards. About 46 were built, most of them for US governmental agencies,



The rather large, 2.25 MHz UNIVAC

and some for big corporations like Westinghouse, General Electric and DuPont. The last UNIVAC remained in service till 1970 with Life and Casualty of Tennessee, an insurance company.

Going Shopping

A UNIVAC was very difficult to maintain, so most customers did not have it shipped; they worked on them at the location where they were built. In fact, the first computer that was installed on location was at the Pentagon for the US Air Force in June 1952.

April: Interactivity!

The Whirlwind, the first interactive computer that worked in real-time, was unveiled at MIT in April. Real-time interactivity means the time lag between your instruction and the response from the computer is barely noticeable—in the order of milliseconds. Before